Russia would also finally officially agree to respect British suzerainty over Afghanistan.[12] One could argue, then, that by the late nineteenth century, Britain had won a decisive victory in the Great Game when it realised hegemony over Afghanistan at the expense of Russian influence there.

The Anglo-Russian Convention

By focusing on events such as war, historians run into difficulties in defining the Great Game. Using diplomatic agreements to set the parameters of the Game is also problematic, as can be seen with the Anglo-Russian Convention of 1907. The culmination of two years of negotiations, the convention was signed between Britain and Russia in August 1907, arguably bringing to an end at least the more overt competition between these two powers that had characterised the Great Game during the nineteenth century. As noted previously, the agreement solidified Britain's position in Afghanistan and also laid out certain terms of interaction in Persia, the other crucial stage of Great Game rivalry. It was the first time that Britain and Russia had managed to negotiate such a truce and, as such, the convention claims great importance in the history of Anglo-Russian relations. Indeed, the nature of the rivalry which had existed between these two nations prior to 1907 makes the creation of the convention all the more significant. As the Russian foreign minister, Serge Sazonov, observed, Britain and Russia's history up until then had been characterised by an 'endless series of political misunderstandings… mutual suspicions and secret and open hostility'.[13] Only a few years prior to the convention, in 1904, these two countries had nearly come to blows over the Dogger Bank incident, while Britain's alliance with Japan during the Russo-Japanese War had further exacerbated Anglo-Russian animosity.[14]

Given what will be discussed later regarding the 1921 Anglo-Soviet Trade Agreement, it is worth understanding what the 1907 convention represented for relations between Britain and Russia. The parallels between these two diplomatic accords is striking, particularly because while both purported to herald a new era in Anglo-Russian relations, in fact neither document was effective in changing the fundamental dynamic between these two